Rebecca: Characters

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Nick Redgrove
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
Updated on 15 October 2024

Characters

It is vital that you understand that characters are often used symbolically to express ideas. Du Maurier uses all of her characters to symbolise various ideas prevalent in her society, and the differences between characters reflect contemporary debates. Therefore, it is very useful not only to learn about each character individually but how they compare and contrast to other characters in the novel.

It is important to consider the range of strategies used by du Maurier to create and develop characters within Rebecca. This includes:

- How characters are established
- How characters are presented:
  - Physical appearance or suggestions about this
  - Their actions and motives
  - What they say and think
  - How they interact with others
  - What others say and think about them
- How far the characters conform to or subvert stereotypes
- Their relationships to other characters

Below you will find character profiles of:

Main characters

- The narrator
- Maxim de Winter
- Rebecca de Winter
- Mrs Danvers

Other characters

- Jack Favell
- Mrs Van Hopper
- Frank Crawley
- Beatrice Lacy
- Ben

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

The narrator

- Du Maurier chooses to present her protagonist without a name throughout the entire text:

Manderley but also by the formidable presence of Rebecca, whose name, in contrast, is known and revered by everyone at Manderley

- From the outset, the narrator struggles with her sense of insecurity and inferiority:
  - Her initial self-perception is tainted by feelings of deep inadequacy
  - These are exacerbated by the **opulence** of Manderley and the lingering presence of Rebecca
- The narrator perceives herself as unsophisticated and out of place in the new aristocratic world she encounters:
  - This further contributes to her persistent sense of unworthiness
- The grandeur of Manderley serves as a constant reminder of the stark contrast between the narrator's modest background and the high society into which she has married:
  - The weight of this comparison is heightened by the memory of Rebecca, who appears to embody grace, sophistication and an unattainable perfection
- The narrator appears to lack the self-assuredness to navigate this new world and she often finds herself paralysed by fear and doubt:
  - The narrator's interactions with Mrs Danvers and other staff members, who were devoted to Rebecca, intensify her feelings of inadequacy
  - Mrs Danvers, in particular, becomes a formidable force that exacerbates the narrator's insecurities
- Initially, the narrator's infatuation with Maxim is marked by a certain naivety and idealisation:
  - Eventually, her initial idealisation gives way to a more mature understanding of her love for him
- As the narrative progresses, the narrator overcomes her insecurity and embraces her individuality:
  - The narrator's transformation is not merely about adapting to the aristocratic world of Manderley but more significantly about her evolving understanding of her own strength and resilience
  - The revelations about Rebecca's true nature and the dynamics of her marriage with Maxim transform her perspective and it allows the narrator to reevaluate her own worth
  - The mature narrator recounting the narrative in retrospect is now no longer haunted but exudes a greater understanding of herself and is more self-confident

Help me understand

Maxim de Winter

- As a character, Maxim is first presented as the mysterious and handsome stranger who has endured the recent tragic loss of his wife

the novel's Gothic atmosphere
    - He acknowledges that he has been "despondent and introspective…my devils for a year"

- Maxim's brooding nature is also reflected in his interactions with other characters, particularly the second Mrs de Winter:
    - The tension in their relationship stems from Maxim's unresolved emotions, which further intensify the enigma surrounding him
    - Maxim's initial reluctance to divulge details about his past, particularly concerning his first wife, Rebecca, creates an element of secrecy

- As a character, Maxim is haunted by his past and his tumultuous marriage to Rebecca:
    - This contributes to the melancholic atmosphere that surrounds Manderley
    - His haunted nature becomes apparent through his recurring nightmares and moments of introspection

- Maxim's character is further complicated by the societal expectations associated with his first marriage:
    - The aristocratic world in which Maxim resides could be viewed as demanding a façade of perfection, especially within the institution of marriage
    - The idealised image of Rebecca, perpetuated by society and even internalised by Maxim himself, becomes a source of conflict

- Maxim's haunted past also contributes to the strained dynamics between him and the second Mrs de Winter:
    - He becomes excessively emotional whenever Rebecca is mentioned
    - They both have an emotional distance between them, which creates an element of isolation for both characters

- In the initial phase of their marriage, Maxim and the narrator have an imbalanced relationship:
    - He assumes a role of detached authority and at times he is dismissive and patronising to the new Mrs de Winter:
        - He casually brushes over her concerns regarding Mrs Danvers and occasionally adopts a patronising tone towards the narrator
        - He fails to recognise the influence and power Mrs Danvers has over his fragile wife

- The revelation of the truth about Rebecca and Maxim's willingness to confront his own vulnerabilities mark a turning point:
    - He becomes a more likeable and vulnerable character after the truth of Rebecca's death is revealed

- In the concluding chapters of the novel, the justification for Maxim's action of killing Rebecca is revealed: Rebecca had terminal cancer:
    - The reader learns that she cunningly manipulated Maxim into hastening her death:
        - This creates empathy for Maxim

- Although Rebecca does not appear physically as a character, she is central to the narrative:
  - Her haunting spirit remains firmly at Manderely and it has a direct influence on the events of the novel
- Rebecca is continually presented to the reader as the **epitome** of beauty and sophistication:
  - She embodies confidence and assertiveness and is the idealised aristocratic wife
- She is portrayed as an object of fascination and admiration for those who encounter her:
  - The descriptions of her elegance and refinement evoke a sense of grandeur and this elevates her to an almost mythical status
- The impact of Rebecca's beauty could be viewed as extending beyond mere **aesthetics**:
  - It shapes the dynamics of Manderley and influences the relationships within it
- Her beauty captivates Maxim but it also casts a spell over the household:
  - This perpetuates an idealised image that becomes both an inspiration and a source of insecurity for the second Mrs de Winter
- Rebecca is therefore a powerful and manipulative force who shapes the lives of those around her:
  - One of the primary manifestations of her manipulation is her influence over Maxim:
    - Despite the appearance of a harmonious marriage, Rebecca's secrets and deceptive nature destroy their relationship
- Mrs Danvers, her devoted housekeeper, is another pawn for Rebecca's manipulation:
  - The loyalty Mrs Danvers maintains to Rebecca, even after her death, illustrates the impact of Rebecca's ability to exert control over those she encountered
- The idealised image of Rebecca, one of of virtue and grace, contrasts sharply with the reality of her manipulations and the revelation of her tragic end:
  - The **dissonance** between the public façade and private reality challenges conventional notions of morality and societal expectations
- Rebecca's character is also in sharp contrast to the second Mrs de Winter:
  - The juxtaposition between the two women links to the themes of identity, societal expectations and the impact of the past on the present
  - The idealised image of Rebecca shapes the protagonist's perception of herself and her place within Manderley

Mrs Danvers

loss and grief over her death

- From the beginning, she is able to exploit the narrator's lack of experience and nervousness:
  - In her eyes, Maxim's new wife is perceived as feeble in contrast to the formidable Rebecca
  - She lacks any warmth or empathy for the narrator and she actively works to undermine her confidence and position
  - Mrs Danvers's influence over the narrator is evident when she nearly convinces her to leap from the window of Rebecca's room

- She is given an **antagonistic** role within the narrative and has a **stoic** and cold demeanour
- She remains fiercely loyal to Rebecca, even after her death, and she becomes a custodian of Rebecca's memory:
  - Her obsessive loyalty to the idealised Rebecca becomes apparent when she refuses to acknowledge any possibility of Rebecca loving Jack Favell:
    - This refusal persists even when it could have aided the case against Maxim

- The physical spaces associated with Rebecca, such as her bedroom and the gallery, become sacred to Mrs Danvers:
  - She meticulously maintains these spaces as if preserving a shrine and ensures that every detail remains as Rebecca left it
  - The obsessive care with which she tends to Rebecca's belongings reflects her deep emotional attachment to her

- Her obsession also contributes to the Gothic tone of the novel:
  - Her eerie display of Rebecca's clothing and possessions ensures that every space associated with Rebecca serves as a constant reminder of her

- Through her manipulative actions and words, she reinforces the myth of Rebecca's perfection:
  - Her dialogue with the new Mrs de Winter is laced with subtle suggestions and comparisons
  - They are deliberately intended to magnify the contrast between the two women
  - She ensures that Rebecca retains a mythical status within Manderley and she becomes a guardian of this illusion

- Towards the end of the novel, the revelation regarding Rebecca's appointment with Dr Baker leaves Mrs Danvers "bewildered":
  - It completely contradicts her belief that Rebecca confided everything to her

Minor Characters

Jack Favell

somewhat **affable** on the surface
    - Despite his charm, he is also portrayed as an unscrupulous and cunning character:
        - He engages in questionable behaviour and harbours a darker and more manipulative side

- He plays a significant role in the mystery surrounding the death of Rebecca:
    - His character becomes entangled in the secrets and scandals of Manderley, which adds suspense and tension to the narrative
    - His actions and revelations play a crucial role in exposing hidden truths and his character contributes significantly to the climax of the text

- His relationship with Maxim is strained and there is clear conflict between the two characters:
    - As a character, he actively opposes Maxim

Mrs Van Hopper

- Mrs Van Hopper is introduced as a wealthy, socially ambitious woman and a somewhat insensitive character who appears in the early parts of the novel
- Du Maurier presents her as a character who seizes any opportunity to climb the social ladder
- She is used as a symbol of the "old world" and its values and her character serves to highlight the tension between different societal norms and expectations
- She often displays a lack of sensitivity and tact in her interactions with other characters:
    - This suggests she is more concerned with her own desires and social standing than with the feelings of those around her

- Her judgements are often based on their societal standing rather than their true character:
    - This is evident in her dismissive attitude towards the narrator when she is her paid companion

Beatrice Lacy

- Beatrice is Maxim's older sister and she is characterised as having a strong sense of familial loyalty and support:
    - She cares deeply for her brother and plays a protective role towards him in the text

- She stands in stark contrast to characters like Mrs Van Hopper, as she is more genuine and compassionate
- Beatrice's conversations contribute to the gradual revelation of the truth about Rebecca

Frank Crawley

- Frank Crawley is the estate manager of Manderley and is presented as Maxim's trusted confidant
- From the moment the narrator arrives at Manderley, Frank befriends her and he offers her support and guidance:
    - His warm and welcoming demeanour provide a source of comfort for the narrator throughout the text

Ben

his cryptic statements, contribute to the sense of foreshadowing in the narrative
- His behaviour and speech add to the overall atmosphere of uncertainty within the novel

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the exam, the idea of character as a conscious construct should be evident throughout your response. You should demonstrate a firm understanding that du Maurier has deliberately created these characters to perform certain functions within her text.

For instance, you could begin to consider why du Maurier has chosen to present the main protagonist in the way that she does. While the other characters are given names within the text, du Maurier purposely does not give her main protagonist a name. Try to explore reasons as to why du Maurier may have chosen to do this and what it might suggest about this character.

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

- Create exam-aligned tests
- Tailor format & difficulty
- Quizzes or homework in minutes

Try Test Builder

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Resources

Learning Hub

Scholarship

Join

Past Papers

Solution Banks

Sitemap

Dashboard

Overview

Brand ambassador

Profile

Subscription

Settings

Log out

Company

About us

Exam Specificity

Content Quality

Promotions

Jobs

Terms

Privacy

Cookie Policy

Help and Support

Subjects

Biology

Chemistry

Physics

Maths

Geography

English Literature

Psychology

All Subjects

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.

Neither IBO nor College Board were involved in the production of, and do not endorse, the resources created by Save My Exams.